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ASLAM HAS WRITTEN A COMPLEX NOVEL IN TERMS OF STYLE, CONTENT AND CHARACTER

Map for a LOST NATION

The book documents the tragedy of Afghanistan in a way no newspaper could

By Sonya Dutta Choudhury



THE WASTED VIGIL
by NADEEM ASLAM
Faber and Faber
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Pages: 372

Thirty miles from the Afghan town of Jalalabad is a large house, by a lake. Here, nailed to the ceiling, with iron spikes driven through them, are hundreds of books. The house is the retreat of the Englishman Marcus Caldwell, former perfume-maker, and husband to the beautiful Afghan doctor, Qatrina, who was stoned to death by the Taliban, a microphone placed next to her to amplify her screams. Her house, with its buried Buddha who cries tears of gold and disused perfume factory, is where the novel's central characters converge. There is ex-CIA agent David Town, tortured by the memory of his dead lover

Zameen. There's Lara, on a hopeless search for her Soviet soldier brother Benedikt, and Casa, a young Afghani jihadi, who unknown to him, is inextricably connected to the house's people.

This is Pakistani born, UK-based Nadeem Aslam's third book, and successor to his much praised *Maps for Lost Lovers*, in which a pair of lovers are brutally murdered for family honour. The book inhabits a bleak and brooding landscape, where the characters, much like the books in Marcus's study, seem to go through life with spikes through their hearts. Why, the novel asks, is it Afghanistan where "even the air of this country has a story to tell about warfare"? Or is it, as Marcus reflects, other people: "But you see, the West was involved in the ruining of this place. There would have been no downfall if this country had been left to itself by those others".

No one side, in this novel, is good. Not the Americans, who stood by and let a refugee camp be bombed by the Soviets (so the Soviets could look bad), not the Soviet soldiers (who like the missing Benedikt, raped and murdered), and not the Aghans (who injected poison into pomegranates and melons sold to Soviets and whose jihadis blow up schools). And yet none of Aslam's characters is bad, and this is the strength of the novel. Bihzad and Casa, the two jihadis, are the most alive characters of all, as Aslam sketches them in detail, grappling almost, to understand their *Lord of the Flies* sort of savagery. So you have Casa recalling, when confronted by his unease at being able to look at Lara laughing, "The madrassa teachers had told the children that women's guile was immense, their mischief noxious, that they were evil and mean-spirited, that all the trials and misfortunes and woes that befell men came from women, that Muhammad, peace be upon him, had said when a woman steps out of the house, Satan is delighted".

It's a complex book then—stylistically (as it goes to and fro in an *English Patient*-kind of way) as well as in content and character. *The Wasted Vigil* is an important novel because it documents the tragedy of a country in a way no newspaper report could. But evaluate it purely as a good read, and it struggles to pass muster, which is sad. If only Aslam didn't go so over the top with his similes (the seeds of a pomegranate are the "temperature of menstrual blood, of semen just emerged from a man's body"). Or with his many, many descriptions and reflections and long-winded asides on subjects like perfumery and painting. And oh for some plot. Nothing seems to happen. And for some pace... ■